

BOX OFFICE MAGIC

► **THE INDIAN BOX OFFICE IS ONE OF THE BIG MIRACLE STORIES TO HAVE EMERGED AFTER THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC**

► **INDIA'S BOX OFFICE HAS EXPERIENCED A NOTABLE GROWTH OF 12%, REACHING \$1.5 BILLION IN 2023 FROM \$1.3 BILLION IN 2019**

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► **BOLLYWOOD WAS ONE OF THE BIGGEST LAGGARDS DURING THE PANDEMIC, AND IMMEDIATELY AFTER. BUT 2023 WAS HINDI CINEMA'S BEST-EVER YEAR, WITH A GROSS BOX OFFICE OF ₹5,380 CRORE**

► **THIS GROWTH IN THE INDIAN FILM INDUSTRY IS PARTLY ON THE BACK OF AVERAGE TICKET PRICES AND NOT ON THE BASIS OF FOOTFALLS. AUDIENCE NUMBERS ARE YET TO BOUNCE BACK WHEN COMPARED TO PRE-PANDEMIC LEVELS**

dia emerge as the sole major market worldwide to surpass pre-pandemic peak box office collections in 2023," he stated in a recent press release.

Additionally, a recent report from market intelligence firm Ormax showed that 2023 marked a historic milestone, with gross box office earnings reaching ₹12,226 crore, making it the first year when the number surpassed the ₹12,000-crore mark in India. But what worked in India's favour? According to Tushar Dhingra, Co-founder & CEO of Dhishoom Cinemas, the answer lies in the country's very robust film culture.

"India has a vibrant theatrical business, which is on its own very prolific and produces a large number of movies. But other major theatrical countries like China, the US and those in Europe have a huge dependency on Hollywood. They have also been laggards because of the Hollywood strikes, which delayed content production," he says.

Within the Indian box office, another miracle story exists and this is about the Hindi film business. Bollywood was one of the biggest laggards during the Covid-19 pandemic, and immediately after, so much so, that obituaries about its eventual demise began to be written about in the media. According to the Ormax report, 2023 was Hindi cinema's best-ever year, with gross box office collections of ₹5,380 crore, crossing the ₹5,000-crore mark for the first time.

But industry experts also point out that there is an issue. This growth in the Indian film industry is partly on the back of average ticket prices that have shot up 22.6% since 2019, since footfalls are yet to bounce back when compared to the pre-pandemic levels. In 2023, the industry registered 943 million footfalls, a growth of a meagre 6% over 2022. During the pre-pandemic year of 2019, it stood at a staggering 1.03 billion.

On the other hand, average ticket

prices have risen more than 22% to ₹130 in 2023, from the pre-pandemic level of ₹106 in 2019. Dhingra admits that this high price of tickets in certain markets in the current environment is an issue and that there is a gap for good quality screens at affordable rates.

"When these big films come, there is a certain section of the population that catches it at the theatres. Others either hold back their consumption or go sparingly to the theatres once or twice a year," he says.

Coming to 2024, industry insiders say the year is already off to a promising start. Telugu movies like *Hanuman* have already grossed over ₹190 crore, while *Guntur Kaaram* has raked in more than ₹140 crore. In the Hindi domain, the Hrithik Roshan-starrer *Fighter*, from the stables of Yash Raj Films, is continuing its dream run, earning ₹140 crore in January. And this growth momentum is set to play the lead role throughout the rest of the year as well with big starrer line-ups like *Teri Baaton Main Aisa Uljha Jiya* and *Article 370*. March, too, will see much-anticipated releases like *Yodha*, starring Siddharth Malhotra; *Laapataa Ladies*, which is produced by Aamir Khan; *Shaitaan*, which stars the ever-bankable Ajay Devgn and R. Madhavan; and *The Crew*, which pairs Kareena Kapoor and Diljit Dosanjh. From the South, there will be big films in February like *Lal Salaam* in Tamil, starring megastar Rajinikanth, *Eagle* in Telugu, which has Ravi Teja, and *Operation Valentine*, in both Telugu and Hindi, starring Varun Tej.

"The tent-pole films are getting established; ₹11,000-13,000 crore collections seem possible in 2024 depending on how the films perform, as there are three to four films each of Akshay Kumar and Ajay Devgn, there's an Aamir Khan film and possibly an SRK film," says Dhishoom Cinemas's Dhingra. **BT**

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